the eye. Almost unconsciously he drifts back to the past and to his childhood's dreams, and visions of belted and armoured knights and fair and brave maidens come to him, and turreted castles and chivalry and quixotic ideas of honour and pride and matchless courage and scorn of death. Especially if he happens to be in Rajputana, that home of romance and of vain and impossible deeds.

But soon the visions fade and a sense of oppression comes; it is stifling and difficult to breathe, and below the still or slow-moving waters there is stagnation and putrefaction. One feels hedged, circumscribed, bound down in mind and body. And one sees the utter backwardness and misery of the people, contrasting vividly with the glaring ostentation of the prince's palace. How much of the wealth of the State flows into that palace for the personal needs and luxuries of the prince, how little goes back to the people in the form of any service! Our princes are terribly expensive to produce and to keep up. What do they give back for this lavish expense on them?

A veil of mystery surrounds these States. Newspapers are not encouraged there, and at the most a literary or semi-official weekly might flourish. Outside newspapers are often barred. Literacy is very low, except in some of the Southern States—Travancore, Cochin, etc.—where it is far higher than in British India. The principal news that comes from the States is of a Viceregal visit, with all its pomp and ceremonial and mutually complimentary speeches, or of an extravagantly celebrated marriage or birthday of the Ruler, or an agrarian rising. Special laws protect the princes from criticism, even in British India, and within the States the mildest criticism is rigorously suppressed. Public meetings are almost unknown, and even meetings for social purposes are often banned.[1] Leading public men

[1] A Press message from Hyderabad, Deccan, dated October 3rd, 1934, states: "A public meeting to celebrate Mr. Gandhi's birthday announced to be held in the local Vivekvardini Theatre yesterday had to be abandoned. The meeting was organised by the Hyderabad Harijan Sevak Sangh (Servants of the Untouchables Society). The secretary of the society, in a letter to the Press, stated that 24 hours before the time of the meeting the authorities demanded that permission to hold the meeting could only be granted on condition that a cash security of Rs. 2000 was furnished and an undertaking given that no speeches of a political nature should be delivered, and no official actions of Government officers should be criticised. As this gave the convener insufficient time to readjust matters with the authorities the meeting had to be abandoned."